descent who were deeply connected to the Indian Subcontinent via the *dharmik* culture of Hindus and Buddhists.[‡] At the dawn of the AD 870, the Saffarids from Zaranj, a city in the south-east of modern Afghanistan, conquered most of what is now Afghanistan. They established Muslim governors throughout the land. This is perhaps the time when the Islamization of land had begun. The situation worsened with the rise of the Ghaznavids in the tenth century.

Though the Zun idol was mutilated, there are texts which talk about it existing till the tenth century. One of the many mentions available is noted below:

> Kábul has a castle celebrated for its strength, accessible only by one road. In it there are Musulmáns, and it has a town, in which are infidels from Hind.— Istahkrí, AD 921[*]

In fact, these people are great evidence to support the theory that Persians were none other than one of the tribes which migrated out of India. They have Persian origin but possessed Central Asian features, and they worshipped Zun from which the Zunbils derived their name.[†]

Politically, and culturally the realms of Zabul and Kābul were considered a part of Al-Hind at the time of initial Muslim conquest. The *Chachnama* for example contains numerous references to Zabul under the corrupt form of *Ramal* or *Ranmal* showing close contacts and marriage relationships between the rulers and subordinate chiefs of Sindh, Kashmir and the king of Zabul in the seventh century. The relationships between these Indian rulers on the north-western frontier appear to have been in constant flux but it seems a safe conclusion that the king of Kashmir had established a claim of suzerainty over Zabul as he had over other Indian Kings.[‡]

So that was a bit of a narrative about the land of Zabuls. Now, we can move ahead, talking about the Umar Shaikh's Amirs.

One of his important Amirs was a descendent of Shaikh Ali Bahadur, one of the Timur's important Begs. Called Baba Quli (‘Ali), he was made Babur's guardian after Shaikh Mazid Beg's death. In AD 1493, Sulṭān Ahmad Ali Mīrzā attacked Andijān and Baba Quli went on to support him. Pleased by his valour and courage, Sulṭān awarded him Aūrā-tīpā. In AD 1494, Sulṭān Ahmad Mīrzā died, and ‘Ali left Samarkand to join Babur. But while he was on the way, Sulṭān Ali Mīrzā, got into a sudden battle over